

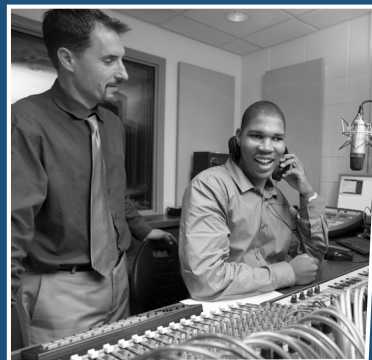
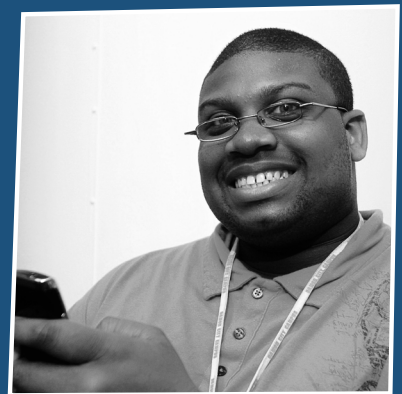
THINK COLLEGE NATIONAL COORDINATING CENTER

Annual Report on the Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities

Year 3 (2012–2013)

Executive Summary

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Higher Education Act as amended in the Higher Education Opportunities Act contained several provisions aimed at increasing access to higher education for youth and adults with intellectual disabilities (ID). One outcome of these provisions was the appropriation of \$10.6 million by Congress to create a model demonstration program aimed at developing inclusive higher education options for people with ID.

In 2010, the Transition Postsecondary Education Program for Students with Intellectual Disability, or TPSID, model demonstration program was implemented by the Office of Postsecondary Education (OPE), which awarded five-year grants to 27 institutes of higher education (IHEs). These IHEs were tasked with creating, expanding, or enhancing high-quality, inclusive higher education experiences to support positive outcomes for individuals with ID.

Congress also appropriated \$330,000 for the establishment of a national coordinating center for the TPSID program. OPE awarded the TPSID National Coordinating Center (NCC) to the Institute for Community Inclusion at the University of Massachusetts Boston in October 2010. The mission of the NCC is to provide technical assistance to IHEs that offer comprehensive transition and postsecondary programs for students with ID. The NCC also evaluates the TPSID projects, creates recommended standards for programs, and builds a valid and reliable knowledge base around program components.

This Year Three Report describes the types of colleges that received TPSID grants, characteristics of attending students, and detailed information about academic access, employment and career development, campus membership, and program elements that supported self-determination, such as person-centered planning. The report also details the TPSID programs' efforts at collaborating with internal and external partners, the extent to which the TPSID programs are integrated into the existing policies and practices of the college, efforts aimed at sustaining these programs, and evaluation strategies employed by the TPSID programs beyond those used by the NCC.

Additionally, the report addresses changes in each of these areas over time, as well as qualitative insights derived from program personnel about critical features and challenges of implementing a TPSID program within a college or university.

PRIMARY FINDINGS OF THE YEAR THREE REPORT

The TPSID programs described here have provided an unprecedented opportunity for 838 students with ID to access college courses, participate in internships and integrated competitive employment, and engage in the same social and personal development activities that other college students enjoy throughout the country.

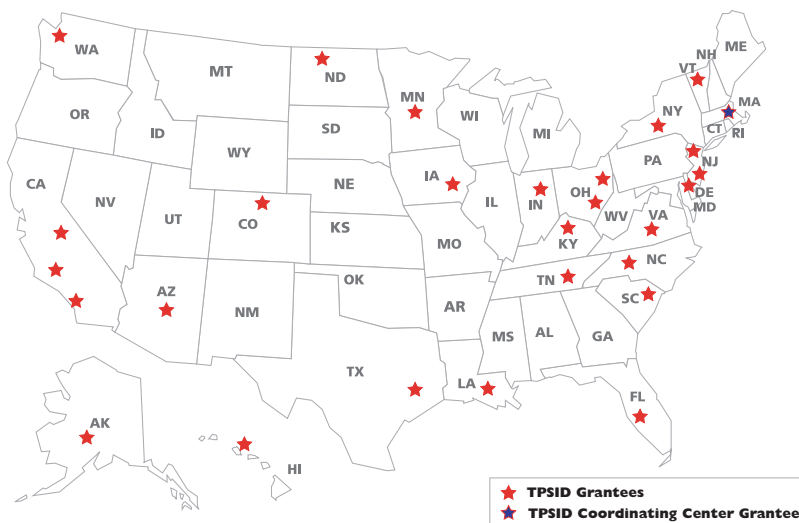
DEMOGRAPHICS

Year Three of the Transition Postsecondary Program for Students with Intellectual Disability (TPSID) program commenced on October 1, 2012 and projects were implemented on 44 college or university campuses in 23 states. In 2012–2013, 15 programs operated on single college campuses and 12 operated as consortia, with various satellite college campuses. Fifteen of these sites were located at two-year Institutes of Higher Education (IHEs) and 29 sites were located at four-year IHEs.

Overall, 838 students attended the 44 TPSID programs in Year Three, for an average of 19 students per site. As of July 2013, ten TPSID sites had been approved as a Comprehensive Transition Program and were able to offer eligible students access to certain forms of Title IV student aid. In the 2012–2013 school year, 838 students attended TPSID programs; of these, 429 students were newly enrolled, 284 had entered the TPSID program in 2011–2012, and 121 students had entered in 2010–2011. The remaining 4 students were returning students for whom year of program entry was unknown because they were from student data reported at the aggregate level.

In 2012–2013, 59% of students were male and 41% female¹. The majority of students were white (73%), 16% were black or African American, and 11% were Hispanic or Latino. Over ninety percent of students were between the ages of 18 and 25, and 95% of enrolled students had an intellectual disability and/or autism. Just under a quarter of students (22%) were dually enrolled, i.e., receiving special education transition services from a public school system while attending the TPSID program.

TRANSITION AND POSTSECONDARY PROGRAMS FOR STUDENTS WITH INTELLECTUAL DISABILITIES GRANTEES



838
STUDENTS



MEDIAN AGE=20
STUDENT AGES RANGED FROM 18 TO 53

59% MALE **41% FEMALE**

22% PERCENTAGE OF STUDENTS WHO WERE STILL RECEIVING TRANSITION SERVICES THROUGH THEIR LOCAL K-12 SCHOOL DISTRICT.

ACADEMIC ACCESS

In Year Three, course enrollment information was reported for 733 of the 838 students who attended TPSID programs. These 733 students enrolled in a total of 5,584 college or university courses. This is an average of 8 courses per student taking courses per year. Students at two-year IHEs took an average of seven courses, while those at four-year IHEs took an average of nine courses a year. A majority of course enrollments (58%) were in academically specialized courses, i.e., courses designed for and delivered to only students with ID in the TPSID. The remaining 42% were in academically inclusive courses, i.e., typical college courses attended by students with an ID and other college students. The percentage of enrollments in inclusive courses was higher at two-year IHEs than at four-year IHEs.

84% of TPSID programs use peer mentors to provide academic supports to students.

The most common accommodations were academic supports such as note-takers and readers. Students also received enrollment accommodations, such as modified course loads, substitutes for required courses, and priority registration, as well as academic accommodations, such as access to professors' notes, advance access to materials, and alternative test formats. A majority of students attending TPSIDs (71%) were seeking a credential in 2012–2013. A majority (84%) of TPSID programs use peer mentors to provide academic supports to students in the programs.

The NCC has offered training and technical assistance on strategies such as Universal Design for Learning and tablet technology to help support greater access to inclusive courses.

University of Vermont

Stirling has a passion for filmmaking and screenwriting and hopes to have her own film production company some day. As a University of Vermont student through Think College Vermont, her academic coursework last year included Written Expression, Introduction to Poetry, Introduction to Acting, and Film Studies.



In addition to her coursework, Stirling participated in two vocational internships. The first was at the local CBS television station, WCAX. The second was at ORCA Media Services, the local cable-access television station. During her internship at ORCA, Stirling often co-hosted a show called *Weekly Photo Challenges*. These internships gave her practical, hands-on experience and the opportunity to meet and work with others in her field of interest.

In Stirling's words, "During my internship at ORCA Media, I learned new techniques on camerawork, editing, and making my own short video. I learned that teamwork is important at ORCA. My internship allowed me to network with real filmmakers and I find that to be totally cool. This internship helped me develop a whole new perspective for networking and asking hard questions about filmmaking."

After completing her certificate program in December 2013, Stirling secured two part-time jobs using her skills in video production. She is now working as the dissemination assistant for Think College Vermont at the University of Vermont. In this role, Stirling produces and edits videos, coordinates social networking through Facebook, Twitter, and YouTube, and helps with marketing and recruitment.

Stirling is working on the Life Histories project, a collaboration between Green Mountain Self-Advocates and the University of Vermont Center on Disability and Community Inclusion. Life Histories are stories of people with disabilities told through speech, writing, art, or video. Stirling's role with Green Mountain Self-Advocates also includes education and outreach regarding disabilities and advocacy.

CAREER DEVELOPMENT AND EMPLOYMENT

Of the 838 students attending TPSID programs in 2012–2013, 298 (36%) held a total of 424 paid jobs. One hundred twenty-seven of students with paid jobs had two or more paid jobs in Year Three. Thirty-five of these jobs (9%) were those that the student also worked in during Year One, and 134 (32%) were jobs the student worked in during Year Two. Forty-two percent of students employed in Year Three had never held a paid job prior to entering the TPSID.

Individual paid jobs accounted for 192 of the paid jobs held by students (45%), and paid internships (credit and non-credit) accounted for 22%. Eighty-two percent of jobs paid at or above minimum wage. In Year Three, 73% of students participated in career development activities, including paid employment, internships or other paid or unpaid career development activities. Length of student attendance impacted rates of employment, the longer students attended, the more likely they were to be employed. Challenges to engaging in paid employment included lack of preparation and career assessment prior to students entering their college program as well as a lack of staff knowledge and training about state-of-the-art customized and integrated employment practices.

36% of students attending a TPSID program held a paid job while attending college. This employment rate is double the national employment average for transition-aged youth with disabilities.

SELF-DETERMINATION

In Year Three of the program, person-centered planning was used in 98% of TPSIDs. Students sought academic advising from existing academic advising offices in 52% of TPSIDs, and 48% (n=21) used only a separate advising system specially designed for students who attend the TPSID.

Common motivations for students to enroll in coursework were that the course: a) was required for the TPSID credential (60% of course enrollments), was related to the student's career goals (53%) or related to a personal interest (41%), or was required for a degree or certificate (31%). Year Three saw more students taking courses because they were related to their career goals (53% of enrollments) than in Year One (44%) and Year Two (39%). A majority of TPSIDs (55%) offered students' families information about IHE-related issues such as social activities (77%), IHE code of conduct (77%), disability-related services available at the IHE (73%), FERPA (66%), non-disability-related services (64%), and financial aid (59%).

To facilitate the development of self-determination in students with intellectual disabilities, the TPSID programs focused on student involvement in the establishment of personal goals through use of person-centered planning, academic advising, and a stated process for family involvement.

CAMPUS MEMBERSHIP

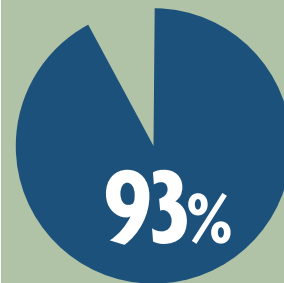
In 2012–2013, every TPSID reported facilitating or supporting student participation in campus social activities including attending events on campus, going out with friends, and attending or participating in sporting events.

Some students participated independently; others received support from TPSID staff or peer mentors. A small minority (8.9%) of students was reported as not participating in any social activities. Addressing some of the inherent risks of college life, such as drinking and sexual behavior, posed challenges to promoting independence and campus participation in some of the TPSIDs.

In 2012–2013, half of TPSIDs (50%) were being implemented at IHEs that did not provide housing to any students. Of those TPSIDs located at IHEs that did offer housing, 14 provided students in the TPSID access to that housing, and eight did not. Most of the 162 students living in TPSID- or IHE-provided housing lived in residence halls or off-campus apartments where most residents were other students attending the college. Just under half of those living off-campus (but not with their families) lived independently, with another quarter in supervised living settings. Students who lived in TPSID or IHE housing generally had higher levels of participation in social activities.

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NUMBER OF PROGRAMS (OUT OF 43) THAT OFFERED THE CHANCE TO LIVE IN CAMPUS HOUSING.



PERCENTAGE OF TPSID STUDENTS IN CAMPUS HOUSING WHO LIVED IN INCLUSIVE STUDENT HOUSING (STUDENTS WITH AND WITHOUT DISABILITIES)

Keuka College

Robert was the first student with an intellectual disability to live on the Keuka College campus as part of the D.R.I.V.E. (Diversity, Responsibility, Inclusion, Vision, and Experiential Learning) Program. During his time at Keuka, Robert contributed to the community and gained self-confidence.

In addition to recruiting college students to become peer mentors for the D.R.I.V.E. Program, Robert worked with Keuka staff to create a video that chronicles his life as a student with an intellectual disability. He often shared his experiences with others in the community and spoke about increasing options for students with disabilities.

Robert served as a member of the student senate, dance team, and D.R.I.V.E. steering committee. He also played a role in managing the college basketball team.

"It made me a new man," says Robert. "I learned a lot in the classroom and on campus with mentors." Robert looks forward to continuing his employment at Keuka, where he will use his skills across a number of departments on campus.



EXITING STUDENTS

A total of 297 students exited their TPSID program in Year Three. The most common reason for exit was having completed the program and earned a credential (52%). Overall, 60% of the students who exited earned one or more credentials before exiting. Students who exited programs at two-year IHEs were slightly more likely to have earned a credential than students who exited programs at four-year IHEs (63% versus 56%). A certificate specifically for students in the TPSID program granted by the IHE was the most common credential at both two-year and four-year IHEs.

Over half of the students who exited in Year Three (57%) were reported as having a paid job, participating in unpaid career development activities, or doing both at the time they exited. At exit, 65 students were working in a paid job, and 133 participated in some sort of unpaid career development activities. Twenty-nine students were both employed for pay and participating in unpaid career development activities when they exited their program. Students who were dually enrolled (in high school and college) were more likely to exit their program with a paid job than students who were enrolled as an adult student for part or all of the time they attended the TPSID.

These data reflect the student's employment status on the day of exit, and do not account for students who gained jobs soon after exiting the program.

EVALUATION

Each TPSID, in addition to using the NCC evaluation system, created its own mechanisms for self-assessment. The evaluation tools used by TPSIDs included assessment of students' academic and career interests and progress, goal attainment, and self-determination. TPSIDs regularly sought feedback from students, faculty, peer mentors, family members, TPSID staff, and employers of students via interviews and meetings.

Thirty six percent of TPSIDs collected follow-up data on students who exited the program, which is an increase from Years 1 and 2.

ALIGNMENT WITH COLLEGE SYSTEMS AND PRACTICES

In Year Three, TPSID programs followed the academic calendar used by the IHE at 93% of the reporting TPSIDs (N=44). The majority (98%) indicated that they held students to the IHE's code of conduct, and 91% issued students college or university ID cards. Eighty-four percent issued students a transcript. Almost two thirds of programs issued regular transcripts. Consistent growth has been seen in the percentage of campuses at which students use career and tutoring services over the first three years of the program.

Sixty percent of TPSIDs stated that students accessed all campus resources that were listed as options. The most commonly accessed resources were the student center, dining hall, bookstore, and library.

COORDINATION AND COLLABORATION

The 44 participating TPSIDs partnered with 236 external organizations. The most common external partnerships in Year Three were with local education agencies (LEAs), vocational rehabilitation (VR) agencies, and state IDD services agencies, with over half of the TPSIDs partnering with these organizations. The three most common partner roles were participating in a project advisory committee, conducting recruitment or outreach, and providing services directly to students. Staff from 84% of TPSIDs participated in professional development from their IHE and 82% had staff that participated in professional development provided by an entity external to the IHE.

The percentage of TPSIDs partnering with employers increased from 29% in Year One to 43% in Year Three.

SUSTAINABILITY

In Year Three, 93% of TPSIDs received financial support from external sources such as State VR agencies, and state IDD services agencies. In 15 of the 28 instances where VR agencies partnered with TPSIDs, the agency provided funds for student tuition. For tuition and non-tuition expenses, private pay (i.e., personal funds) was the option most commonly used. Tuitions were waived for various reasons for 14% of students. Ten TPSIDs were approved Comprehensive Transition Programs (CTPs), and could offer eligible students access to certain forms of federal student aid. Pell Grants were the most common form of federal student aid. Annual costs varied widely ranging from no cost at all to \$51,000, and depended upon the type of institution (two-year or four-year) and whether the IHE charges were residency-dependent, e.g. in-state, out-of-state, city resident, etc.

TPSID programs that are approved Comprehensive Transition Programs

Appalachian State University
California State University, Fresno
Camden County College
College of Charleston
Kent State University
Monroe Community College
Taft College
The College of New Jersey
University of California Los Angeles
Western Carolina University



CONCLUSION

The findings of this Year 3 Annual Report reflect that the TPSID programs continue to make substantial progress toward their goals. As the number of students served in these programs grows, so does knowledge of what policies and practices lead to better outcomes. At the completion of three years of funding, noticeable trends are beginning to emerge. Data show that the longer a student is in a program, the more likely they are to be employed. Also, the type of IHE seems to be influencing employment outcomes, as students enrolled in programs at two-year IHEs were nearly twice as likely to have paid jobs as students at four-year IHEs. Finally, it appears that students who attended programs in which they had greater access to inclusive coursework were more likely to participate in both paid employment and other career development activities than students who attended programs that offered primarily specialized courses.

As these programs continue to evolve, the focus on the credentials earned will grow and become more important. When the TPSID programs commenced, many were focused on establishing the program by increasing enrollment and accessing the college environment. A shift is now needed to focus greater attention on the credentials earned and the outcomes achieved.

We hope that this report will foster interest and engagement by legislators, federal agencies, state leaders, and education professionals to embed inclusive higher education into future transition and employment initiatives nationwide.

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www.thinkcollege.net/publications/tpsid-annual-reports

RECOMMENDED CITATION

Grigal, M., Hart, D., Smith, F. A., Domin, D., Sulewski, J., Weir, C. (2014). *Think College National Coordinating Center: Annual report on the transition and postsecondary programs for students with intellectual disabilities (2012–2013)—Executive Summary*. Boston, MA: University of Massachusetts Boston, Institute for Community Inclusion.